COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS

BeReal Passport & Community Boards — Competitive Analysis

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> *Independent concept created for a UI/UX Design & Product Management Externship. Not affiliated with or endorsed by BeReal.*

Summary

Every major social app competes for the same daily habit, but they win it in different ways. **TikTok** wins with an endless algorithmic feed. **Instagram** wins with scale and copies new formats quickly. **Snapchat** wins with streaks that people are afraid to lose. **Locket** wins with quiet, close-friends presence on the home screen.

BeReal's position is distinct: **real photos, real friends, no performance**. Its weakness is that it offers one reason to open the app per day, and that reason can feel like pressure.

BeReal Passport & Community Boards adds a second reason to come back, collecting and sharing with your squad, *without* adopting the pressure mechanics BeReal was built against. The feature itself can be copied. What's hard to copy is that it only makes sense on a platform built around authenticity, small groups, and no public likes.

Market context

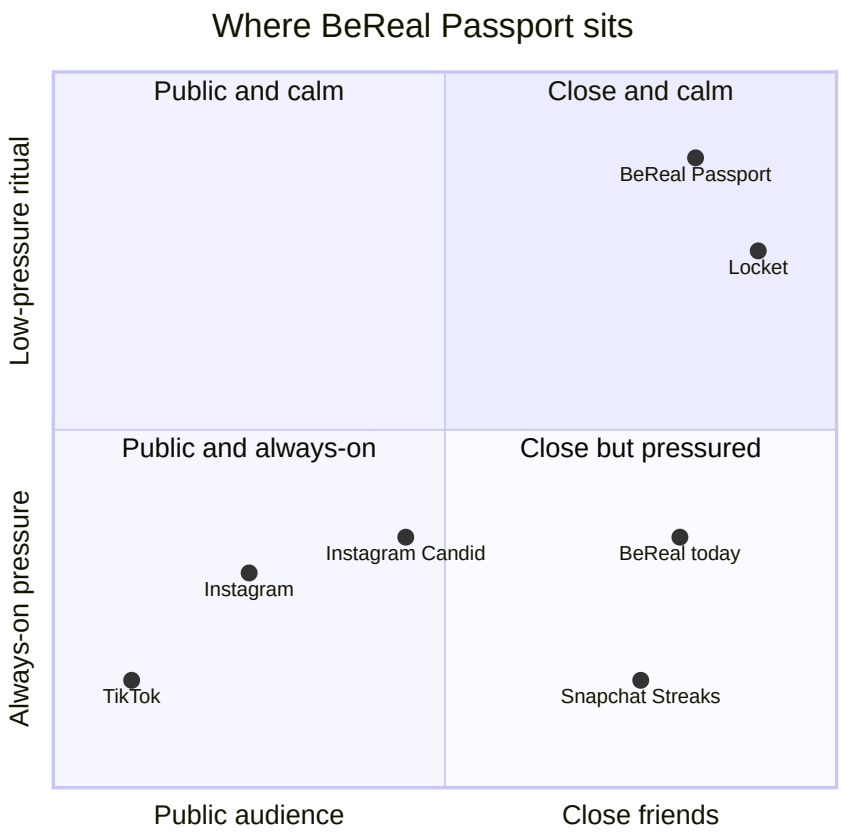
Fact	Detail	Source
BeReal's 2022 peak	73.5M monthly active users in August 2022, up from 21.6M in July	Wikipedia
BeReal's decline	Daily users fell about 61%, from roughly 15M (October 2022) to under 6M (March 2023), per Apptopia	Platformer, citing The New York Times
Fast copying by competitors	Instagram added Dual Camera (July 2022) and Candid Stories (announced December 2022); TikTok launched TikTok Now (September 2022)	Engadget, Wikipedia
Acquisition	Voodoo acquired BeReal in June 2024 for a reported €500M, citing about 40M active users, about half of them on 6+ days a week	Konvoy
Close-friends apps growing	Locket has 91M+ lifetime installs and 100K+ subscribers; its weekly "Rollcall" recap is posted by over 25% of active users	TechCrunch, Nov 2025
TikTok time spent	About 95 minutes per user per day (third-party estimate, undated)	Omnicore, via NGPF

Data note: a widely repeated claim that BeReal has "72% daily engagement among active users" traces back to aggregator sites with no date or original source, and it conflicts with other published figures. I left it out. When the numbers disagree, the analysis relies on dated, attributed sources.

Competitive landscape

	TikTok	Instagram	Snapchat	Locket	BeReal today	BeReal + Passport
Core loop	Endless algorithmic video feed	Feed, Stories and Reels from people you follow	Messaging with friends	Friends' photos appear on your home-screen widget	One timed, dual-camera photo a day	The daily BeReal, plus optional themed squad boards
Audience	Public, strangers	Mostly public, with Close Friends lists	Friends	Close friends	Friends	Small squads
Main retention hook	Variable reward: what's next?	Social validation (likes, views)	Streaks: don't break the chain	Ambient presence	The random daily alert	Collection: stamps, capsules and the monthly board
Pressure level	High (time sink)	High (performance)	High (loss-framed streaks)	Low	Medium (2-minute timer)	**Low** (no timer, no public likes, no streak to lose)
Gap it leaves	Not about your friends	Curated, not real	Pressure and obligation	Little shared occasion or progression	One reason to open per day	—

Positioning map



The **close-and-calm** quadrant is the least crowded. Locket owns quiet presence there, but it offers no shared occasion and no progression. BeReal Passport moves BeReal into that space by adding monthly themes and collecting, which Locket lacks.

Feature benchmarks: what drives retention today

From my research into how the two most relevant apps keep users coming back:

TikTok

Feature	What it is	How it drives retention
For You Page	An algorithm-driven, endless feed based on watch time and behavior, not just who you follow	A variable reward loop: users never know what's next, so they keep scrolling
Duets and Stitch	Tools to remix, respond to or build on someone else's video	Turns watching into participating; people return to check responses and join trends
Hashtag challenges and streaks	Viral challenges, plus streak tracking and flame badges	A gamified layer of progression and social reward for showing up regularly

BeReal

Feature	What it is	How it drives retention
Daily random notification	One alert at a random time, with a 2-minute window to post a dual-camera photo	A daily check-in built on unpredictability; keeps the app top of mind
Locked feed (no peeking)	Friends' posts stay hidden until you post	Reciprocity: you have to post before you can browse
RealMoji reactions	Reactions made from a photo of your own face	A two-way interaction that pulls people back to see responses

Takeaway: TikTok keeps people engaged through discovery and gamification, without needing a friend network. BeReal's loop is built on friends and reciprocity, but it gives users only **one reason a day** to open the app. The working session shows how I turned these mechanics into features → Feature Working Session

Why build this in BeReal, not Instagram or Locket?

Interviewer question	Answer
Why not just use Instagram?	Instagram's business runs on public reach, likes and ads, which is the performance culture BeReal users are avoiding. Its BeReal copy (Candid Stories) borrowed the *format* but not the *trust*.
Why not Locket?	Locket is close-friends and calm, but it's ambient. It has no shared occasion, no theme to rally around, and no collection that builds over time.
Why not Snapchat Streaks?	Streaks work through fear of loss. BeReal Passport rewards showing up ("You've been real 3 days in a row — no streak to lose") without punishing a missed day.
Why BeReal?	BeReal already has the hardest parts: an authentic dual-camera format, a friend graph, and a brand people trust to be real. Passport adds the missing **second reason to open the app**.

What stops a competitor from copying this?

Honestly, the feature can be copied. Instagram shipped BeReal's camera format within months. Defensibility doesn't come from the feature; it comes from four things around it:

Moat	Why it's hard to copy
1. Brand fit	Squad-only reactions, no public likes and opt-in only conflict with an engagement- and ads-driven model. A competitor *can* build it, but it undercuts their core business.
2. Switching costs that grow	Every month adds stamps to your Passport and a capsule to your Memories. Your collection lives in BeReal and can't move to another app.

Moat	Why it's hard to copy
3. Small-group network effects	A board is only fun if *your squad* is on it. Once a squad's monthly ritual lives in BeReal, moving it takes everyone switching together.
4. Operating cadence	New themed and sponsored stamps every month is an ongoing content operation, not a one-time feature. Speed and taste compound over time.

Risk response: ship fast, keep the monthly cadence, and build sponsor partnerships that fit BeReal's brand, so that by the time a copy appears, squads already have months of collections.

Borrow, adapt, avoid

Mechanic	Seen in	Decision	How it shows up in BeReal Passport
Themed challenges	TikTok	**Adapt**	Monthly themed boards (HIKE, CRAMMING, COFFEE, HAUNTED)
Progression badges	TikTok, Snapchat	**Adapt**	Collectible Real Passport stamps, with no loss framing
Streaks	Snapchat, TikTok	**Soften**	"You've been real 3 days in a row" — no streak to lose
Reciprocity (post to see)	BeReal	**Keep**	Friends' posts stay blurred until you post
Face-based reactions	BeReal (RealMoji)	**Keep and focus**	Squad-only reactions, no public like counts
Close-friends intimacy	Locket	**Adopt**	Small squads instead of a wide friend list
Weekly recap ritual	Locket (Rollcall)	**Adapt**	Monthly capsule saved to Memories
Endless algorithmic feed	TikTok, Instagram	**Avoid**	Boards are time-boxed and close each month
Public likes and follower counts	Instagram, TikTok	**Avoid**	No public metrics anywhere

Sources

- BeReal — Wikipedia
- How BeReal missed its moment — Platformer (Apr 2023), citing The New York Times and Apptopia
- Instagram launches its BeReal clone, Candid Stories — Engadget (Dec 2022)
- Voodoo gets real — Konvoy (Jun 2024)
- Locket's social app is picking up steam with Gen Alpha — TechCrunch (Nov 2025)
- How long does the average user spend on TikTok a day? — NGPF, citing Omnicore